

Christy Ennis-Kloote

Experience Designer & Local UX Community Leadership

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Natural optimist driven to find solutions to any design challenge, particularly those that traverse complex systems, together in a cross-functional team. I have built multiple teams that have delivered multi-modal product experiences in various markets, including consumer, B2B, medical, and automotive. My background in Industrial Design, which I apply today in UX (HCD), drives me to understand and seek out users' unmet needs, and address them in the execution of the product or service. As a lifetime consultant and community builder, I am motivated to learn constantly. These learnings influence customers, clients, and product strategy with a new perspective, enabling a larger impact on the approach and resulting in more meaningful outcomes.

Experience

2025-04 - Current

Chief Design Officer

Augusto Digital, Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Leading digital experience strategy at Augusto Digital, grew the overall company book of business by 50% by attracting top talent and expanding offerings.
- Designing innovative offerings valued by clients and integrating AI and Agentic Automation into workflows for enhanced efficiency.
- Collaborating with build teams to deliver delightful and practical products, driving company success.

2023-05 - Current

Peer Advisor

Latticework Consulting, Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Through Latticework, I coach and consult with leaders on removing barriers for designers to do their best work.
- The breadth of services extend from building in-house UX teams and capabilities to advocacy in an organization.
- Get teams unstuck typically in the first week with tangible results in the first 30 days.
- Establish a trusting relationship with each client by maintaining professionalism and honoring confidentiality.

2022-08 - 2025-04

Experience Design Services Director

Augusto Digital, Grand Rapids Metropolitan Area

- Led and grew the Experience Design, Product Services, and Growth Marketing teams, growing headcount to the top-performing service line with reliable best-in-class margins of 40-50%.

- I developed strategies to enhance service delivery, customer satisfaction, and profit margin goals.
- Constantly collaborated with other departments to align on strategic initiatives.
- I drove growth through innovative marketing and product strategies.
- Worked closely with the sales team on effective pre-sales.
- Engaged as an integral part of the Augusto leadership team and adopted and implemented EOS.

2022-03 - 2024-01

Managing Director of Experience Design

Argenta Park, Kalamazoo, Michigan

- As a young studio with momentum, my experience is being applied to build and manage a healthy and happy team that brings out our best creative selves.
- This lets the team focus on uniquely creative product experience concepts to solve human and business problems for our clients.
- I manage all aspects of design operations for the organization, including development, methods, tools, and budget.
- I work in partnership to set and implement strategic direction, which creates healthier profitability of our 14+ members without impeding creativity.

2015-04 - 2022-09

Manuscript Technical Reviewer

O'Reilly Media, Grand Rapids, MI

- Provide chapter-by-chapter critical and constructive feedback as a practicing professional for over 20+ manuscripts before going to print., such as Articulating Design Decisions, Product Roadmaps Relaunched, and Product Leadership.
- It's fast-paced and best if thorough, but rewarding to participate in the revision process for professional publishing.

2018-07 - 2022-03

Principal, Design Practice Manager

Open Systems Technologies, Inc., Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- I concluded my time at OST, leading and managing the Professional Services Design Practice which consists of up to 25+ team members across three geographies (and an extended remote team).
- For the business, I am tasked to achieve practice goals including sales, GM%, and utilization.
- Daily activities revolve around ownership of thought leadership, market pricing, and delivery strategy for the practice and across OST's multidisciplinary teams while also ensuring culture and business goals are aligned through behaviors and outcomes.
- Growth and development of the team is also a key focus to ensure constant evolution to meet the needs in the ever-changing consulting market.

2018-10 - 2019-10

2019 Organizing Chair

MidwestUX, Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Oversight and vision for the 2019 conference which includes plan, curation of the 2019 program, building the core team and identifying committee leads, engaging community for balanced representation, and managing budget oversight for sponsorship and ticket sales.

2017-11 - 2018-07

Principal, Director of Product Design

Open Systems Technologies, Inc., Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Through the acquisition of Visualhero and the subsequent formation of Open Digital, an OST offering, I developed frameworks to guide entire user experiences. I led special and innovative projects, identifying new opportunities for value creation.
- When developing the product strategy, I collaborated with product owners and stakeholders to understand the problem and offer solutions in balance with the larger program offering.
- I worked with clients and stakeholders to bring the team you need to balance internal expertise, managing budgets ranging from \$15k to \$500k.
- I discovered my passion working within all levels of the organization to mentor other contributors and leaders to develop new practices and thought leadership that increased value for experience design.
- My focus was Connected Solutions and Product Design where I connected strategy and vision with day-to-day practicality.

2018-01 - 2018-06

Instructor of Product Design

coLearning Professional Education, Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Students explore the product design and development process from brand-new startup phase to the relaunch of a current product over 12 weeks.
- The students learn to articulate how the design and development of a product align with the organization's business goals and vision.
- Course participants practice collaborating in small teams with product owners to apply new methods to a single real-world product.

2013-02 - 2017-12

Director of Experience Design

Visualhero Design Company (Acquired by OST), Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Worked closely with clients large and small to discover opportunities in the unknown, where we can make meaningful and engaging experiences for end users and product owners.
- Developed new patterns and practices, enhancing methodological toolkit.
- Used facilitation skills to engage cross-functional teams in strategy, communications, and design of services.
- Managed teams of designers to delegate work in agile cross-functional environments on a family of products simultaneously.
- Lead the delivery of shipped products from embedded systems, web apps, and mobile experiences, and connected solutions that ranged from 3 weeks to 3 years to deliver.

2015-01 - 2015-12

Adjunct Instructor: New Media Design

Kendall College of Art and Design, Greater Grand Rapids, Michigan

- Teaching concepts and methodologies of user experience design through various digital formats, such as mobile phone or desktop, for a classroom of up to 14 students.
- The outcome was the creation of interactive products presented through video storytelling with the use of images, text, gestures, and interactivity.

- Defined and articulated goal learning outcomes, performance metrics, and changes to improve student learning.
- Mentored struggling students with targeted one-on-one assistance, leading to improved academic performance.

2012-02 - 2013-02

Lead UX Designer/Project Manager

Visualhero Design Company (Acquired by OST), Grand Rapids, MI

- Quickly moved into a UX leadership role at VH for multiple shipped products with a multinational technology company headquartered in Cupertino.
- I guided team approach for addressing the design problem for each piece of the family of solutions in the product suite.
- In all projects, I push to apply studio methods such as personas, journey maps, and user flows while managing complexity.
- As I got to know the team, I steered studio traffic planning and inspired team creativity and pride through the art and power of cake.

2011-08 - 2012-02

UX Designer / Visual Designer

Universal Mind, Grand Rapids, Michigan

Contracted for Mobile & Web Applications for large organizations and worked independently with little oversight on projects ranging from consumer language learning platforms to financial products.

Skills Applied: Design Standards · Design Management · Consulting

2006-08 - 2012-02

Lead Graphic Design | User Interface

Tiger Studio, Zeeland/Holland, MI

- Lead and represent Graphics / UI teams in UI behavior/experience, visual theme, brand identity, marketing strategy, business development, project approach/planning, estimates/proposals, project schedules, creative direction, and team workload.

Education

1997-01 - 2002-01

BS, BA: Industrial Design, German, Art

Western Michigan University - Kalamazoo, MI

1999-01 - 2000-01

Some College (No Degree): Industrial Design, German Language

Kunsthochschule Berlin-Weissensee - Hochschule Für Gestaltung - Berlin Germany

Publications

- Facilitating Creative Culture
- Embrace A Shared Cadence To Avoid Silos

Awards

GRBJ 40 Under 40 Honoree

Top Skills

- Customer Experience Design
- Professional Services
- Project Planning
- Strategic Communications
- Product Strategy & Roadmaps
- Multi-Platform Experiences
- User Experience Design
- System Design
- Business Strategy & Proposals
- Team Building
- Design leadership
- Strategic thinking
- Design thinking

Languages

German